How to Write About Your Art

Part 3: The Artist Statement

ARTIST COMMONS

“You never know what you will learn ’til you start writing.
Then you discover truths you never knew existed.”

– Anita Brookner

“Nothing begins good, but everything good begins.
Everything can be revised, erased, or rearranged later.
The courage of creation is making bad beginnings.”

– Kevin Ashton

“We lack words,
and we have too many of them.”

– Susan Sontag

Warm-Up Exercise

Describe Your Morning

- Use only one syllable words.
- This forces you into more concrete language.

Your Homework

- Put what you just wrote in a drawer.
- Next week, pull it out and mark the good bits:
  - Underline the strong sentences
  - Circle the strong phrases
  - Box the strong words
- Copy those into a Word document.
- Rearrange those fragments into paragraphs.
- Play with the order.
- Then write the connective tissue.

“I have rewritten—often several times—every word I have ever published. My pencils outlast their erasers.”

– Vladimir Nabokov

“I write to find what I have to say.
I edit to figure out how to say it right.”

– Cheryl Strayed

“The writing begins when you’ve finished.
Only then do you know what you’re trying to say.”

– Mark Twain

Revision Exercise

Hotspotting

- Go through your recent draft and mark the most meaningful sentences.
- Copy/paste one of those key sentences into a new page.
- Use that sentence as the jumping off point to write some new text around that idea.
- Compare the new material to what you'd previously written. Which do you like better?
- Sub in some of the new sections you just wrote.

“One maxim that my students find helpful is: One thought per sentence. Readers only process one thought at a time. So give them time to digest the first set of facts you want them to know. Then give them the next piece of information they need to know, which further explains the first fact. Be grateful for the period. Writing is so hard that all us, once launched, tend to ramble. Instead of a period we use a comma, followed by a transitional word (and, while), and soon we have strayed into a wilderness that seems to have no road back out. Let the humble period be your savior. There’s no sentence too short to be acceptable in the eyes of God.”

– William Zinsser

“Grammar is a piano I play by ear. All I know about grammar is its power.”

– Joan Didion

“Style is a very simple matter; it is all rhythm. Once you get that, you can’t use the wrong words.”

– Virginia Woolf

“Variety is the key. Most people write the same sentence over and over again. The same number of words—say, 8-10, or 10-12. The same sentence structure. Try to become stretchy—if you generally write 8 words, throw a 20 word sentence in there, and a few three-word shorties. If you’re generally a 20 word writer, make sure you throw in some threes, fivers and sevens, just to keep the reader from going crosseyed.”

– Janet Fitch

“Pick a better verb. Most people use 20 verbs to describe everything from a run in their stocking to the explosion of an atomic bomb.”

– J. Fitch

“Look for verbs of muscle,
adjectives of exactitude.”

– Mary Oliver

Editing Hacks

- Read your piece aloud
- Change the font and reread it
- Print out your draft and edit it by hand
- Change where the piece starts
- Cut all abstractions from the first paragraph
- Anticipate misunderstandings
- Change words for their connotation (e.g. odor vs. aroma)
- Identify the words and phrases you intend to make people feel the work.
- Always use an editor

Exercise

Writing Partner: Interview

- Sit down with your writing partner for coffee.
- Record yourself explaining the piece/series to them.
- Or, have them look at the piece and ask you questions about it.
- Transcribe and edit the recording to form the backbone of your first draft.

Revision Exercise

Writing Partner: Revision

- Swap artist statements and revise your partner's writing while they revise your statement.
- Red Star Revision Exercise:
  - Make a print out of your artist statement.
  - Each time you feel your attention drifting, mark that point in the text with a red star.

“Writing teaches writing.”

– John McPhee

Reading List

- Art-Write – Vicki Krohn Amorose
- How to Write About Contemporary Art – Gilda Williams
- Dreyer’s English: An Utterly Correct Guide to Clarity and Style – Ben Dreyer
- The Craft of Research: Fifth Edition
- The Artist as Critic – Oscar Wilde
- An Experiment in Criticism – C.S. Lewis

“There are so many different kinds of writing and so many ways to work that the only rule is this: do what works. Almost everything has been tried and found to succeed for somebody. The methods, even the ideas, of successful writers contradict each other in a most heartening way, and the only element I find common to all successful writers is persistence—an overwhelming determination to succeed.”

– Sophy Burnham